Eclipse Court — Mobile Design Proposal

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Concept

Eclipse Court is a two-sided fantasy chess game where every capture is settled by a short real-time duel, played with one thumb on a phone. Two courts, the Solari (light) and the Umbral (dark), fight over a board whose squares slowly drift between light and dark, so *when* you attack matters as much as *where*.

Four pillars:

- **Chess clarity, arcade spice.** The board reads at a glance; the duel is where skill shows.
- **Time is a resource.** The same fight is easy now and brutal four rounds from now.
- **Upsets stay possible.** A skilled player can beat a stronger piece, so no capture is a foregone conclusion.
- **Phone first.** Portrait, one thumb, 5 to 15 minute matches.

Eclipse Court is a working title. Mechanics are inspired by Archon; every piece, name and spell here is original.

What made Archon work

Archon (Free Fall Associates, 1983) fused a slow chess-like board with a fast action arena, and the join between them is the whole game. When a piece moves onto an enemy, both are pulled into an arena and fight in real time for the square. A stronger piece usually wins but not always, and both can die.

The mechanics worth keeping:

- **Luminance.** The board has fixed light and dark squares plus a large set that cycles between them. Light pieces are harder to beat on light squares, dark pieces on dark ones.
- **Distinct duel styles.** Pieces fight by melee, by missiles, or with an area burst, so every matchup plays differently.
- **Spellcasting leaders.** Each side's leader teleports and has seven one-use spells. Pieces on power points can't be targeted by magic.
- **Wounds persist.** A winner returns to the board hurt and heals slowly.

- **Power points.** Holding them all wins the game, which gives the board a goal besides killing.

Its sequel, Archon II: Adept, swapped the one-use spells for unlimited casting that drains the player's base, and moved to an elemental board.

What changes for a phone:

Original	Eclipse Court	Why
Two joysticks, one screen	One thumb vs AI first; pass-and-play later	A phone has one screen and two thumbs, not two controllers
18 pieces per side, 9 by 9 board	12 pieces, 7 by 7 board (open question)	Shorter matches, bigger tap targets
Duels run until someone dies	20 second cap, then sudden death	Keeps the board turn rhythm
Two-axis joystick aiming	Auto-aim plus one button	Thumb aiming is imprecise
No difficulty options	Aim assist, duel speed, auto-duel	Wider audience

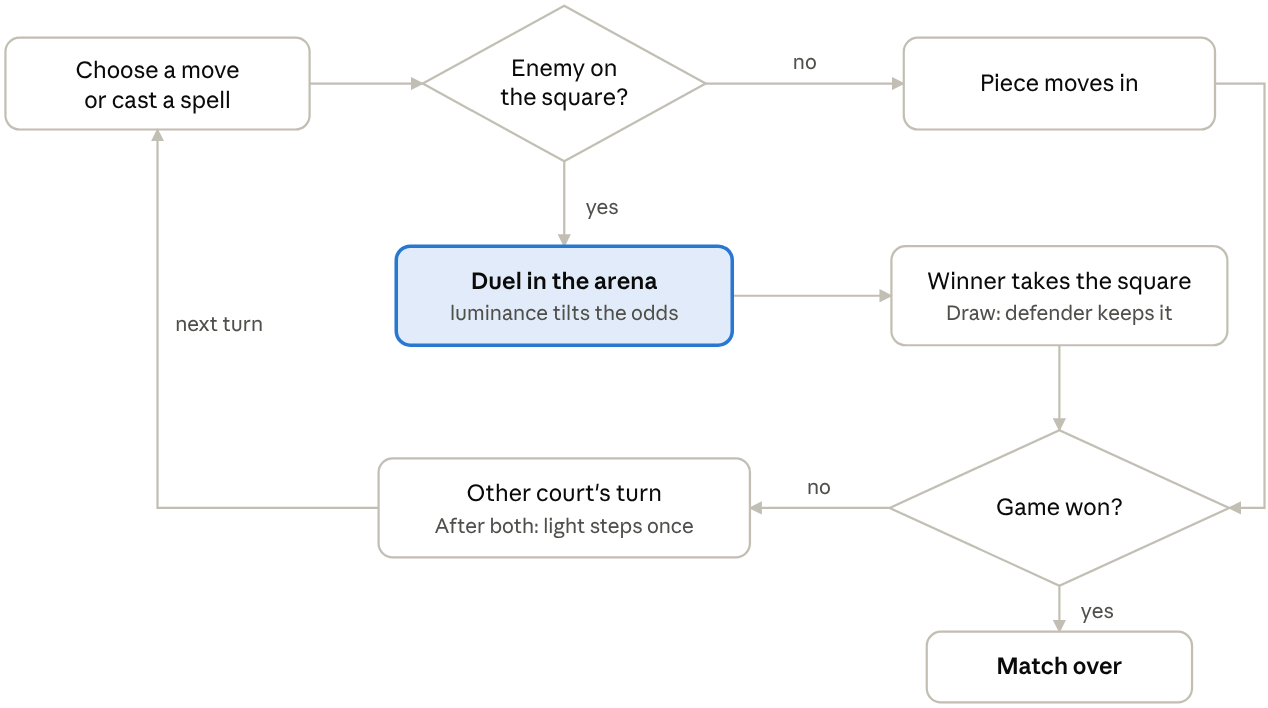
Archon's own inspirations were a Conan chess set, a living chess match staged by the Society for Creative Anachronism, and the holographic chess scene in Star Wars.

Sources: Archon: The Light and the Dark (Wikipedia) · Archon II: Adept (Wikipedia) · Original EA manual · Archon tropes · The Sons of Archon · Computer Gamer review

Core loop

A turn is a chess move; only a capture sends the game into the arena, and the winner carries its wounds back to the board.

Only a capture sends the game into the arena



core loop · 2 decisions, 1 duel

A move onto an empty square just happens. A move onto an enemy triggers a duel. Both paths end at the win check, and after both courts have moved the luminance steps once.

Board and luminance

The 7×7 board has 26 fixed squares and a 23-square diamond in the middle that pulses between light and dark. The left side is always light (13 squares: the two left corner regions plus the left-edge middle), the right side always dark (13), and the diamond cycles. The diamond is every square within 3 steps of the center, except the two home-edge middles.

Luminance runs from -2 (deep dark) to +2 (full light). It advances one step each round, where a round is one move by each side, on an 8-round day: -2, -1, 0, +1, +2, +1, 0, -1. Each ring of the diamond lags the one inside it by a step, so light ripples outward and players can read what's coming. A dial at the top of the screen shows the next three steps.

Duel effect. In a duel on a square with luminance L, the favoured court deals 15% more damage and takes 10% less per step of |L|, up to +30% and -20%. At L = 0 (dusk) nobody is favoured. Fixed squares are always at +2 or -2 for their court.

Beacons. Five squares are beacons: the two home-edge middles (fixed), the center, and the top and bottom middles (all cycling). A piece on a beacon can't be targeted by spells and heals one extra pip per round.

Winning. Hold all five beacons at the end of your turn, or eliminate every enemy piece. If 30 rounds pass, the **Eclipse** begins: luminance freezes at 0 and every piece off a beacon loses 1 HP per round, which forces a result.

Roster

Each court fields 12 pieces across 7 roles: the roles match, but the duels feel different. The Solari favour reliable straight-line shots and bursts of speed; the Umbral favour lobbed shots, regeneration and attrition.

Role (count)	Solari	Umbral	Board move	Duel style
Footsoldier (4)	Lumen Knight	Gloom Ghoul	1 square, any direction	Short melee swing; lowest HP
Flier (2)	Sunhawk	Night Raven	Up to 3 squares, over pieces	Fast dash, light darts
Marksman (2)	Gilded Archer	Bone Slinger	Up to 2 squares	Archer: straight arrow, slow reload. Slinger: lobbed arc that clears barriers
Bruiser (1)	Dawn Golem	Mire Troll	1 square	Slow, highest HP, heavy slam. Troll regenerates during the duel
Charger (1)	Radiant Stag	Shadow Panther	Knight jump (L-shape)	Charge or pounce; glass cannon
Aura (1)	Seraph	Wraith	Up to 3 squares, over pieces	No projectile; damaging pulse when close. Wraith passes through barriers
Leader (1)	Solarch	Duskmother	Teleports to any empty square within 4	Magic bolt, moderate HP; casts spells

Stats. Each piece has HP in pips (Footsoldier 4, Leader 7, Bruiser 10), duel speed, and damage per hit. Exact numbers come from the balance simulator, not by hand.

Wounds. A winning piece keeps its remaining HP. It heals 1 pip every 2 rounds if it didn't move, and 1 extra pip on a beacon.

Capture rule. Moving onto an enemy starts a duel. The defender keeps the square if the duel ends in a draw.

Spells

Each leader has seven spells, each usable once per game, and every cast costs the leader 1 HP and the whole turn. That makes spells a real trade: a wounded leader can't afford them, and a leader in a duel is a target.

Spell	Effect
Blink	Move any one of your pieces to any empty square
Mend	Restore 4 pips to one friendly piece
Turn the Hour	Reverse the direction of the luminance cycle
Swap	Exchange the positions of any two pieces, friend or foe
Conjure	Summon a neutral spirit onto an empty square to duel one enemy piece; it vanishes afterwards
Revive	Return one captured friendly piece to your home edge at half HP
Bind	Freeze one enemy piece for 2 rounds: it can't move, and it defends at half HP

Limits. Pieces on a beacon can't be targeted. Leaders can't target each other with Bind. The Eclipse (round 30) disables spells.

Touch controls and duels

The duel is the riskiest part of the design, so it is built around one thumb stick and one button. If this doesn't feel good on a phone, the game doesn't work, so it gets prototyped and tuned first.

Strategy board

- Tap a piece, legal squares glow, tap a square to move. Dragging works too.
- Long-press any piece for its stat card and luminance forecast.
- Moving onto an enemy shows the odds (a win-chance bar from stats and luminance) and an Attack button before committing.

Duel arena

- Portrait arena, your fighter at the bottom, theirs at the top. The arena background and barriers pulse with the square's luminance.
- **Left thumb:** floating stick that appears wherever you touch the left 60% of the screen. **Right thumb:** one big attack button, with a left-hand mirror option.
- **Auto-aim:** ranged attacks fire toward the opponent within a forgiving cone, so there is no second stick. Hold the button to charge a stronger shot.
- **Length:** 20 seconds. Then sudden death shrinks the arena until someone is hit. Draw: the defender keeps the square.
- **Feedback:** 60 ms hit-stop, screen shake, and haptics where the device supports vibration.

Accessibility and options

- Duel speed 0.75× or 1×.
- Aim-assist strength: off, low, high.
- **Auto-duel:** the AI plays your fighter at 80% skill, for people who only want the strategy.
- Pass-and-play (later): phone flat on a table, each player gets a thumb pad on their own half of the screen.

Modes and AI

Launch with a single-player game against a convincing AI, and add modes that reuse the same engine.

Mode	What it is	Phase
Skirmish	One match vs AI at three difficulties	Launch
Campaign	Eight opponents, each with a handicap or a changed starting setup	Launch
Daily puzzle	Preset board: win or capture the leader in a set number of moves	After launch
Pass-and-play	Two players, one phone, split-thumb duels	After launch
Async online	Turn-based over the network, duels replayed from a seed	Later (needs a backend)

Strategy AI. A depth-limited search (2 to 3 moves ahead) that scores each capture by a predicted duel win chance. That chance comes from a matchup table built by the balance simulator, adjusted for luminance and wounds. Its evaluation rewards beacon control and attacking while its court is favoured by the cycle.

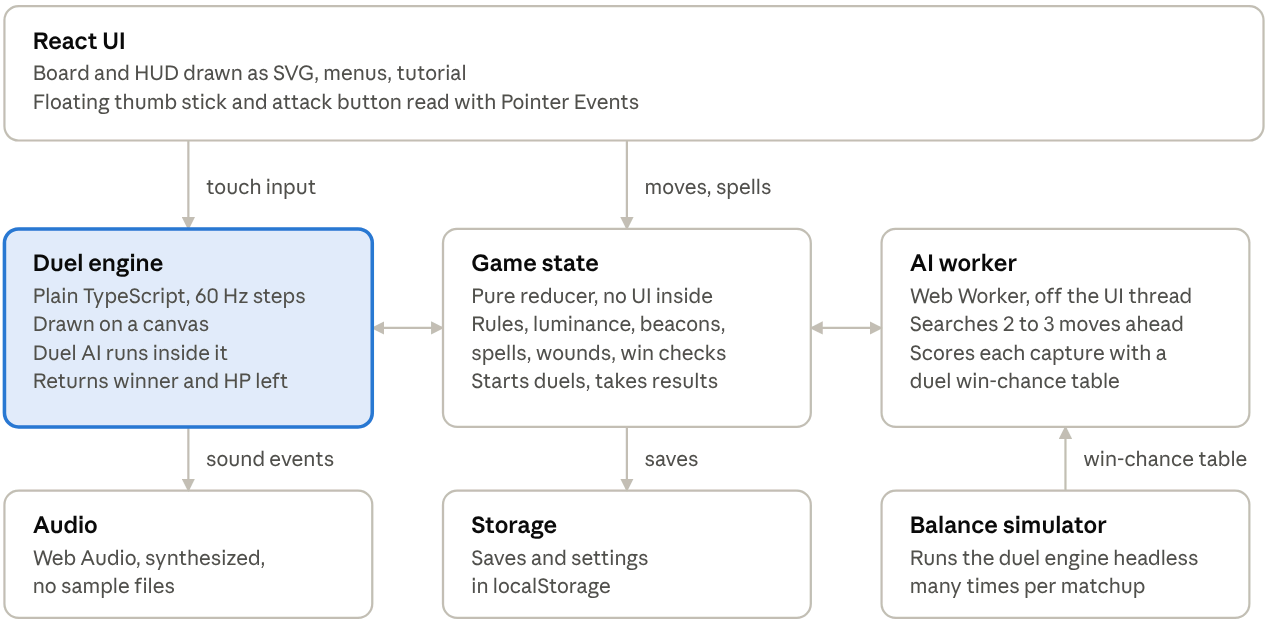
Duel AI. One behaviour state machine per piece type (approach, kite, dodge, fire). Difficulty is set by reaction delay, aim error and how often it dodges, never by stat cheating, so a hard AI feels skilful rather than unfair.

Runs off the main thread. The search runs in a Web Worker so the board never stutters.

Technical architecture

React draws the board and menus; a framework-free engine runs the duels, so the 60 Hz loop never waits on a React render.

React draws the board while a separate engine runs the duel



architecture · 3 core modules, 3 support parts

The game-state reducer is pure and deterministic, which gives undo, save and replay for free, and later lets an online match re-run a duel from a seed.

- **Stack:** Vite, React, TypeScript, plain CSS, no game framework.
- **Offline:** installable PWA with a service worker; an optional single-file build for simple hosting.
- **Tests:** Vitest on the rules, plus the headless simulator for duel balance and stress tests.

Art, audio and UX

The look is stained glass and cut paper: two palettes, drawn entirely as SVG, so the whole game is a few hundred KB. Solari are warm gold and cream; Umbral are indigo and violet. No image files are needed.

- **Luminance as light.** Cycling squares glow and ripple outward from the center. A sun and moon dial at the top shows the next three steps.
- **Portrait layout.** Top: round counter and dial. Middle: the board. Bottom: a tray with the selected piece's card, the spell button and End Turn, all inside thumb reach.
- **Duel arena.** Themed by the square's luminance: barriers pulse in and out, and the arena shifts from warm to cold as the cycle turns.

- **Audio.** Synthesized with Web Audio, no sample files. Board play is a quiet pad; a duel adds percussion; the two courts have a high and a low bell motif.
- **Juice.** Hit-stop, shake, damage numbers, a slow-motion beat on the final blow.
- **First-time play.** A 3-minute tutorial board: one move, one duel, one luminance shift, one spell.

Build order, risks and decisions

Once you approve this, I can build it in one pass in this order, with the duel feel tuned first because it carries the most risk.

1. Rules engine and board: moves, luminance, beacons, win checks, with captures auto-resolved by stats.
2. Duel engine and touch controls for three piece types; tune until it feels right.
3. Full roster, spells, wounds and the Eclipse rule.
4. Strategy AI and duel AI with three difficulty levels.
5. Art, audio, tutorial, installable offline app.
6. Balance simulation (thousands of headless duels per matchup) and stress tests.

Risks

Risk	Mitigation
Duels feel clumsy on touch	Single stick, auto-aim, early prototype, aim-assist options
Matches run too long	7×7 board, 20 second duels, Eclipse at round 30
Pieces unbalanced	Headless balance simulator tunes stats
AI search stutters the UI	Web Worker
Too close to Archon	Original roster, spells and rules; only the core concept is shared

Decisions needed

- [ ] Board size: 7×7 with 12 pieces (recommended) or 9×9 with 18
- [ ] Launch scope: vs AI only, or include pass-and-play
- [ ] Duel orientation: portrait (recommended) or landscape lock

- [ ] Theme: keep Solari and Umbral, or re-skin (sci-fi, steampunk, and so on)
- [ ] Delivery: React project, or also a single self-contained HTML build for easy hosting